

Dīnc'iy/dīnc'ey (lesson four)

Inner subject prefixes to verbs (part 2)

Recall from last time that the inner subject prefixes always appear just before the final syllable of the verb. We talked about 'I', which has the shapes **s-**, **c-** or **gi-**, depending on the sound that follows, and we also talked about 'we du.', which has the shapes **dit-**, **did-**, or **di-**, depending on what follows. In this lesson we will tackle the two remaining inner subjects.

'You (sg.)' (Second person singular, 2sg)

The prefix marking 'you (sg.)' has several forms: **īn-**, **ī-**, **n-**, **en-**, **e-** and nothing. The forms of this prefix are determined by the sounds that precede and follow it.

(1) The basic form of the prefix meaning 'you (sg.)' is **īn-**, as seen in the following examples, where the prefix is word-initial. These are imperfective verbs, so we expect to see **i-** marking imperfective, but **i** is deleted before **ī**:

īncagh (i-īn-cagh)	'you're big'
īntsagh	'you're crying'
īn'ën	'you see him/her/it'
lhk'u īnlī	'you are smart'

In the next set of examples, 'you (sg.)' is still **īn-**. These examples contain **ni-** 'around' (the continuative prefix). The vowel **i** of the continuative prefix is deleted before the vowel **ī** of **īn-** 'you (sg.)'.

nīnzut (ni-i-īn-zut)	'skate around, you're skating around'
nīnghī	'you're packing him/her/it around'
nīnghīh	'pack him/her/it around'
nīnlīh	'carry them (things) around'

(2) When the following sound is **lh** or **l** followed by another consonant, the element which means 'you (sg.)' is simply **ī-**:

īlhcot (īn-lh-cot)	'you took it, take it'
īlkh'agh	'you're fat'
yīlh'is	'you're sneezing'
nīlh'ën	'look at him/her/it'

nīlgit (n-īn-l-git)

'you're afraid'

nīlc'ēkh

'you're having a tantrum'

(3) 'you (sg.)' is **en-** when the preceding consonant is one of:

p	t	ts	tl	c	kw	k	
	t'	ts'	tl'	c'	kw'	k'	'
		s	lh	yh	wh	kh	h

sende

'you're sitting'

sendeh

'sit'

senbiz

'you stretched it'

c'entl'o ~ c'entl'iw

'knit, you're knitting (something)'

'enlegh

'you made it'

(4) 'you (sg.)' is simply **e** when the preceding consonant is one in the above table and (a) the following consonant is **n**:

hene

'you're alive'

or (b) when the following consonant is **lh** or **l** followed by another consonant:

selhc'ilh

'you bit him/her/it'

selhghil

'you bundled it'

ghisel'ay

'you're wearing it on yourself (pin, badge, etc.)'

'elh'ah

'work on it'

(5) When the preceding sound is a vowel other than **i**, then 'you (sg.)' is simply **n**:

unzī (u-īn-zī)

'you're calling his/her name'

untan

'hold it'

dendzin?

'how are you?' (also means 'how is he/she/it?')

(6) When the preceding sound is a vowel other than **i**, and the following sound is **lh** or **l** followed by another consonant, then there is no overt marker of 'you (sg.)'. Such forms usually (always?) have more than one meaning.

haltal our laughing')	'you burst out laughing' (also means 'he/she burst out laughing')
těł'ën pitiful')	'you're pitiful' (poor you)' (also means 'he/she is pitiful')
yelhdic	'you're talking' (also means 'he/she is talking')

'You (pl.)' (Second person plural, 2 pl)

The basic form of 'you (pl.)' is **wh-**.

dew wh dzin?	'how are you (pl.)?'
ï wh 'ën	'you (pl.) see him/her/it'

In the first example, the second person plural prefix is preceded by **de-** 'how, what' and in the second example the preceding prefix is **i-** progressive, respectively. The first form is imperfective but the imperfective prefix is deleted after the vowel of **de-**.

When the second person plural subject prefix is in an imperfective form with no other prefixes to their left, then **i-** imperfective occurs before **wh-**, and the **wh** causes **i** to sound like a short o (the whole **iwh** syllable is unstressed).

hi wh cagh (i-wh-cagh --> hiwhcagh)	'you (pl.) are big'
hi wh tsagh	'you (pl.) are crying'
lhk'u hi wh li	'you (pl.) are smart'

However, in such cases, one other sound is needed, because no Witsuwit'en word begins with **i**: an **h** must be inserted, and that is why the above words begin with **hiwh**.

hi**wh**cagh (from i-wh-cagh --> h-i-wh-cagh) 'you (pl.) are big'

The **h** is not needed when there is another prefix before the imperfective **i**:

c'ï wh tl'o ~ c'ï wh tl'iw	'you (pl.) are knitting'
ni wh zut	'skate around (you pl.)'
ni wh ghih	'pack him/her/it around (you pl.)'
ni wh lih	'carry them around (you pl.)'

Also note that depending on the verb, **wh-** can mean 'you (du.)' instead of 'you (pl.)':

si**wh**këh 'sit (you du.)'

When the following sound is **lh**, note that the presence of **wh-** 'you (pl.)' creates a cluster of two consonants (both are pronounced):

yew**hl**hdic 'you (pl.) are talking'

ï**wh**lhcot 'you (pl.) took it, are taking it'

yi**wh**lh'is 'you (pl.) are sneezing'

si**wh**lh'ilh 'you (pl.) bit him/her/it'

si**wh**lhghil 'you (pl.) bundled it'

ni**wh**lh'ën 'look at him/her/it (you pl.)'

'i**wh**lh'ah 'work on it (you pl.)'

hi**wh**lhk'agh 'you (pl.) are fat'

When the following sound is **l** followed by another consonant, then **wh** causes **l** to become **lh**:

ghisi**wh**lh'ay 'you (pl.) are wearing it on yourselves (pin, badge, etc.)' cf. ghisel'ay 'you're wearing it on yourself'

të**wh**lh'ën 'you (pl.) are pitiful' (poor you guys)' cf. tël'ën 'poor you, poor him/her'

si**wh**lh'ëgh 'you (pl.) are mad (sitting and mad)' cf. selc'ëgh 'you're sitting mad'

ni**wh**lh'ëkh 'you (pl.) are having a tantrum' cf. nïlc'ëkh 'you're having a tantrum'

ni**wh**lhgit 'you (pl.) are afraid' nïlgit 'you're afraid'

haw**wh**lhtal 'you (pl.) burst out laughing' haltal 'you, he/she burst out laughing'

When the preceding sound is **u** or **o**, then 'you (pl.)' is simply **h**:

uhzï 'you (pl.) are calling his/her name'

uhtan 'hold it (you pl.)'

'oht'ah wibe 'oondzin 'you (pl.) should work'

Writing practice (second person subject prefixes)

If you know one form of a verb with an inner subject prefix, you should now be able to predict the first person singular, first person dual or either of the second person subject forms. (In real life sometimes you need to know more than one form in order to accurately predict all the other forms, but we will practice that now in a limited way.) That is, if you know **his'alh** 'I'm eating it', you should know that **s-** is 'I' and you can substitute **wh-** for **s-** to form 'you pl. eat it' (**hiwh'alh**), **dit-** 'we du.' for **s-** to form 'we du. are eating it' (**hidit'alh**), and **in-** for **s-** to form 'you eat it' (**in'alh**). The last form is the only tricky one: the **h** which had to be inserted before **i** is not needed before **ĩ** so goes away. Now try to fill in the blanks in the following examples:

ka bĩ sichcoz	'I keep it (blanket) in the car'
_____	'you (sg.) keep it in the car'
_____	'you (pl.) keep it in the car'
senlĩ	'you became'
_____	'you (pl.) became'
bidust'ën	'I look like him/her'
_____	'you look like him/her'
_____	'you (pl.) look like him/her'
_____	'we (du.) look like him/her'
nĩnye	'you're walking around'
_____	'I'm walking around'
ĩwh'is	'you (du.) are walking'
_____	'we (du.) are walking'
nidit'as	'we (du.) are walking around'
_____	'walk around (you du.)'
bĩtlat	'jump into it (bus, car etc.)'
_____	'jump into it (you pl.)' (bus)

Future

In lesson three you learned about the imperfective and progressive, the first of four important time categories of Witsuwit'en. Another major time category is the future, which is formed in a way somewhat similar to the progressive. Remember that the progressive prefix is **ë-** or **ĩ-** depending on what the preceding sound is. The progressive is **ë-** after these sounds:

p	t	ts	tl	c	kw	k	
	t'	ts'	tl'	c'	kw'	k'	'
		s	lh	yh	wh	kh	h

The progressive is **ĩ-** in all other cases (when preceded by other consonants, or when word-initial). The progressive prefix occurs to the left of all the inner subject prefixes:

ïsyelh 'I'm walking'

cf. **ïyelh** 'he/she is walking'

ïnyelh 'you're walking'

ïdit'is 'we du. are walking'

ïwh'is 'you du. are walking'

There are also sometimes changes to the final syllable between the progressive and imperfective which are sometimes but not always easy to predict (e.g. **nisye** 'I'm walking around', **ïsyelh** 'I'm walking').

The future consists of two prefixes, **t-** and **a-** or **ĩ-** (in that order). (**ĩ-** is only used in negative forms, so we will not deal with that form for quite a while.) For now we will think of **t-** and **a-** as occurring in the same position as the progressive and imperfective, immediately to the left of the inner subject prefixes. Compare the progressive forms above with corresponding future ones:

tasyelh 'I'm going to go, walk'

cf. **tayelh** 'he/she is going to go, walk'

tanyelh 'you're going to go, walk'

tadit'is 'we (du.) are doing to go, walk'

tawh'is 'you (du.) are going to go, walk'

Here are some more examples of imperfective vs. future:

nisye 'I'm walking around'

nitasyelh 'I'm going to walk around'

nīnye 'you're walking around'

nitanyelh 'you're going to walk around'

niwh'as 'you (du.) are walking around'

nitawh'as 'you (du.) are going to walk around'

nidit'as 'we (du.) are walking around'

nitadit'as 'we (du.) are going to walk around'

Here are more examples of progressive vs. future:

it'ikh 'it's flying'

tat'ikh 'it's going to fly (away)'

dīdildis 'we (du.) are in a rush, driving fast' **ditadildis** 'we (du.) are going to rush off, will be in a rush'

iskēlh 'I'm boating'

taskēlh 'I'm going to go (by boat)'

Writing practice (future)

The following assorted imperfective, progressive or future forms will be dictated to you. Write them in the spaces provided:

'I'm working'

'I'm going to work'

'I see it'

'I'll see it'

'we (du.) are laughing'

'we (du.) will laugh'

'stand'

'stand (you du.)'

'you will stand'

'you (du.) will stand'

'get in (car)'

'get in (car) (you du.)'

'stand up'

'stand up (you du.)'